



have engaged in a form of ritual warfare known as “tinkuy”. The spilling of blood on the ground was believed to ensure the earth’s fertility, so the purpose of this type of conflict was not outright conquest. As in their major battles, the Inca forces’ superiority in numbers would also have helped them in this ritualized form of combat.

### THE COMING OF THE EUROPEANS

The arrival of Europeans, in Mexico in 1519, and in Peru in 1532, heralded the rapid collapse of the principal pre-Columbian civilizations. Although Spanish military technology was superior – they possessed firearms, horses, and metal armour – their numbers were vastly inferior. They achieved a series of victories through their advanced weapons, but also through military aggression, by disregarding Aztec and Inca ritual proprieties (such as the Inca reluctance to fight at the new moon), and by exploiting the resentment that existed among the subject peoples of the two empires. Once the vulnerability of the Inca and Aztec emperors had been established, the Spanish, who then arrived in greater numbers, never allowed their opponents to regain their strength. The Aztec empire lasted only until 1521, when it was overthrown by the Spanish; by 1572, the last Inca stronghold had also fallen.



### KEY EVENTS

#### 800–1550

■ **c.800–830** The Classic Mayan civilization collapses. The main cities of the Maya – Calakmul, Tikal, and Yaxchilan – are abandoned one by one, for reasons that are not clear, but may have included the effects of overpopulation on poor land.

■ **1428** The Aztecs of Tenochtitlán form a triple alliance with the neighbouring city-states of Texcoco and Tlacopan, marking the start of the Aztec rise to power in the Valley of Mexico.

■ **c.1470** After a series of campaigns, the Pachacuti Inca conquer the Chimor capital at Chanchan, giving them dominance in the Andes.

■ **1519–21** The Spanish, under the command of Hernan Cortes, overthrow the Aztec empire.

■ **1529–33** Led by Francisco Pizarro, the Spanish overthrow the Inca, capturing and killing the Inca emperor Atahualpa.

### KEY TRADITION

#### AZTEC FLOWER WARS

The Aztecs and neighbouring tribes indulged in a type of ritual fighting known as “flower wars”. At an agreed time and place, restricted numbers of warriors armed with non-lethal weapons would fight; captives on either side were taken off and used for human sacrifice.



▲ Aztec warriors as depicted in the *Codex Mendoza*, an Aztec pictorial record dated around 1541.

### ◀ WARRIOR GOD

Mixcoatl was the Aztec god of hunting and warfare, and is normally pictured with warpaint, a bow, and his kills.